
- RAG Learning

2.2 Language and Gender

AQA A-Level English Language (7702) — Paper 2 Section A

Language and Gender studies how gender interacts with linguistic choices. The field has developed through **four major frames**: deficit (Lakoff), dominance (Zimmerman & West, Fishman), difference (Tannen), and performativity / community of practice (Butler, Eckert & McConnell-Ginet, Cameron). A top-band answer moves *across* these frames rather than settling on one.

2.2.1 The Deficit Model — Lakoff (1975)

Robin Lakoff's *Language and Woman's Place* (1975) was foundational. She proposed that "women's language" is characterised by features that make it less assertive than men's:

- **Hedges** — "sort of", "I think", "kind of".
- **Tag questions** — "...isn't it?"
- **Rising intonation on declaratives** (uptalk) — turning statements into checks.
- **"Empty" evaluative adjectives** — "divine", "lovely", "adorable".
- **Hypercorrect grammar** — avoidance of stigmatised forms.
- **Super-polite forms** — indirect requests, apologies.
- **Intensifiers** — "so", "really".
- **Avoidance of strong swearing.**

Criticism: Lakoff's list was based on introspection and anecdote, not systematic study. It treats women's language as *deviating from a male norm*. It also confounds power with gender.

2.2.2 The Dominance Model

Zimmerman & West (1975)

Analysed 31 conversations (20 same-sex, 11 mixed). Found that in mixed-sex dyads, men accounted for 96% of interruptions (46 out of 48). Argued this reflected **male conversational dominance**.

Fishman (1978/1983)

Pamela Fishman taped heterosexual couples at home. Found:

- Women asked nearly three times as many questions as men.
- Women used minimal responses ("mm", "yeah") to sustain topic continuity.
- Men's topics succeeded 96% of the time; women's only 36%.

Argued women do the "conversational shitwork" — the interactional labour of keeping conversation going while men benefit.

O'Barr & Atkins (1980) — a critique from within dominance

Studied US courtroom witnesses. Found Lakoff's "women's language" features correlated with **power status**, not gender. Low-status speakers — regardless of gender — used those features. Renamed "powerless language". Key critique: the deficit model confounds gender and power.

2.2.3 The Difference Model — Tannen (1990)

Deborah Tannen's *You Just Don't Understand* argued men and women are socialised into different communicative subcultures:

Tannen's binary	"Male" style	"Female" style
Orientation	Status	Connection
Talk type	Report talk	Rapport talk
Focus	Information, problem-solving	Empathy, relationship

Response style	Advice	Understanding
Conflict	Direct, competitive	Indirect, cooperative

Tannen's framework became very popular, but has been heavily criticised (see 2.2.5 below).

2.2.4 Other Important Research

Holmes (1992)

Janet Holmes argued tag questions have MULTIPLE functions:

- **Epistemic** — checking information ("It's at 3, isn't it?")
- **Facilitative** — inviting response ("Lovely weather, isn't it?")
- **Softening** — mitigating directness ("That's not quite right, is it?")
- **Challenging** — pushing an addressee ("You did call him, didn't you?")

Found women used facilitative tags more than men — but this is ABOUT MANAGING INTERACTION, not weakness. A powerful critique of Lakoff's deficit reading.

Coates

Jennifer Coates studied all-women friendship groups and found highly cooperative features: mutual topic development, supportive overlap, epistemic modality, shared humour. Argued women's talk is often *collaborative* rather than weak.

Spender (1980)

Dale Spender's *Man Made Language* argued that the English language itself, shaped historically by men, encodes male power. Evidence: generic masculine, lexical asymmetry, naming conventions. Strong form has been critiqued for determinism, but the observation about lexical bias is widely accepted.

2.2.5 Critique of the Difference Model — Cameron (2007)

Deborah Cameron's *The Myth of Mars and Venus* argues gender differences in language are widely **overstated**:

- Meta-analyses show small average differences and *very large within-gender variation*.
- Men and women overlap heavily; the "two cultures" narrative erases this overlap.
- The "difference" frame can exonerate sexist behaviour by reframing it as cultural misunderstanding.
- Popular books (Gray, Tannen) promote the binary for commercial, not scientific, reasons.

Cameron's argument is that gender differences in language, where they exist, emerge from context, power and community of practice — not from innate or categorical difference.

2.2.6 Performativity — Butler (1990)

Judith Butler's concept of **performativity** reframes gender: it is not something we HAVE but something we DO through repeated acts. Language is central — the way we speak helps PRODUCE our gender identity.

Implications:

- There is no "essential" male or female voice.
- What sounds "feminine" or "masculine" is a socially-recognised performance.
- Non-binary and fluid gender performances are linguistically legible.
- Analysis should ask "what kind of gender is being performed?" rather than "who is the speaker?"

2.2.7 Community of Practice — Eckert & McConnell-Ginet (1992)

Penelope Eckert and Sally McConnell-Ginet proposed shifting from static gender categories to **communities of practice**. A community of practice is a group that coheres around shared practices and goals — a sports team, a workplace, a friendship group. Members develop shared repertoires including linguistic ones.

Benefit: accommodates intersectionality — speakers belong to multiple communities, each shaping their idiolect. Gender is one factor among several that includes class, ethnicity, age and sexuality.

2.2.8 Gendered Lexis and Representation

Lexical asymmetry

Word pairs where the female form has narrower or negative connotations:

- master / mistress
- bachelor / spinster
- governor / governess
- sir / madam (madam can mean brothel-keeper)

Generic masculine

- "chairman", "fireman", "mankind", "manhole" — male as default.
- Historical use of "he" to refer to any person.

Marked forms

- "female doctor", "lady MP", "woman writer" — female as the marked case, male as unmarked.

Representation in media

Tabloids consistently use different adjectives for women than men in equivalent roles — "emotional", "shrill", "bossy" for women; "assertive", "decisive" for men. Focus on appearance vs policy. Use of first name vs title. These representational patterns are a productive focus for language-discourse analysis.

2.2.9 Contemporary Debates

- **Singular "they"** — resurging for gender-neutral and non-binary reference. Recognised by dictionaries and major style guides.
- **Inclusive lexis** — "spokesperson", "firefighter", "chairperson".
- **Pronoun declarations** — naming one's pronouns in professional contexts as a marker of inclusive practice.
- **Gender-neutral address** — e.g. "Mx" as a title alongside "Mr/Ms".

These changes are linguistically unremarkable — languages adapt to user needs — but often provoke language discourses, providing rich material for Paper 2 Section B.

Applied Example: A speech by a female politician uses hedges, inclusive "we" and rhetorical questions. Lakoff might label these "women's language"; Holmes would note their facilitative function; Cameron would ask whether they are really gendered or part of the speech genre; Butler would ask what kind of political femininity is being performed. Integrating these lenses — rather than picking one — is what top-band analysis looks like.

2.2.10 How to Analyse Gender in a Text

1. Identify **specific linguistic features** (not just "men / women talk differently").
2. Consider **multiple frameworks** — what would deficit, dominance, difference and performativity each say?
3. Ask about **power and role** (O'Barr & Atkins) — is the feature better explained by status than gender?
4. Consider the **community of practice** — which communities is the speaker performing in?
5. Discuss **representation** — how is gender constructed in the text?
6. Evaluate — avoid essentialist claims; acknowledge within-gender variation.

Exam Tip: Never reason "speaker is female → feature = women's language". That move has been discredited for decades. Top-band answers treat gender as one contextual factor among several and integrate multiple theorists.

Key Terms Checklist

Make sure you can define: **deficit / dominance / difference / performativity models, hedges, tag questions, uptalk, minimal responses, generic masculine, marked female form, lexical asymmetry, interruption vs supportive overlap, community of practice, report talk / rapport**

talk, verbal hygiene. Theorists: **Lakoff, Zimmerman & West, Fishman, O'Barr & Atkins, Tannen, Holmes, Coates, Spender, Cameron, Butler, Eckert & McConnell-Ginet.**